Summary

The findings highlight significant friction caused by social awkwardness, lack of visibility into peers' working styles, and mismatched grade ambitions.

Key Findings:

1. Pre-semester Planning and Class Grouping

Through the ECP, students identify whether a course includes a group project before the semester starts. Students who are well-prepared and have rich social networks will lock in peer group early, leaving remaining students to rely on icebreaker activities or tutor intervention.

> *"So, as you know, we usually know which courses have group projects beforehand because all assignments are listed in the ECP before the semester starts."*

> *"I actually messaged a friend before class because I saw the ECP listed a group project, but by the time I reached out, his group was already locked in."*

2. Late Allocation and Platform Limitations

While discussion boards (e.g. Ed Dashboard, Microsoft Teams) exist for team recruitment, they yield low engagement. Unassigned or absent students are typically plugged into incomplete teams, introducing uncertainty for existing group members.

> *"We posted on the dashboard discussion board after class, but nobody replied for a couple of days. Eventually, in Week 2, the tutor randomly placed a student into our group who hadn't shown up to the Week 1 tutorial. That's pretty common, tutors will just plug absent people into teams that aren't full yet."*

3. Evaluating Teammates: Prioritizing Reliability Over Social Compatibility

Student evaluate teammates through a reliability-first lens. Rather than relying on peer reputation, students use direct past experience and early process cues (e.g. communication responsiveness) as key risk indicators. Importantly, students prioritize task reliability over social likability, expressing a strong preference for quiet but dependable peers over friendly but procrastinating ones.

"Someone can be super quiet or not my usual friend type, but if they complete their work reliably and communicate on time, they're a great teammate. On the other hand, someone can be really friendly and fun, but if they procrastinate and leave work unfinished, it creates a lot of stress."

4. **Overcoming Random Grouping Through Structure**

When assigned randomly, teams experience initial inertia due to social hesitation. Successful performance in random groups requires an individual to step up and establish explicit tasks and soft deadlines.

"At first, it was pretty slow. People were polite, but nobody wanted to take charge. A few weeks in, as a draft deadline was approaching, progress was lagging. I stepped up and suggested a clear breakdown of tasks with soft deadlines. Once everyone had specific roles assigned, they actually followed through well. It just required more effort upfront to establish structure."

5. **Core Alignment Metrics**

When deciding whether to partner with someone, students prioritize alignment on two dimensions: Target Grade and Working Style.

"Two main things: target grade, whether someone wants a 6-7 or just passing, and working style, whether they like working ahead of time or doing things closer to the internal deadlines. Matching those saves a lot of friction."

Design Implications:

1. **Multi-Dimensional Profile Matching (Matching Criteria)**

Implement a structured pre-grouping questionnaire that captures student working preferences and academic ambitions rather than relying on brief in-class icebreaker.

2. **Smart and Balanced Group Allocation (Algorithmic Logic)**

Move away from pure random grouping. Instead, use an algorithm that pairs students with compatible expectations and complementary skills, ensuring balanced capabilities across teams without sacrificing ambition alignment.

3. **Mitigating Social Friction in Self-Selection (Lowering Social Barriers)**

Provide a system-mediated buffer that enables students to filter or match based on objective data rather than uncomfortable personal negotiations.

4. **Early Structural Anchors for Tutor-Assigned Groups (Post-Grouping Support)**

Automatically scaffold newly formed teams with structural templates, clear task breakdowns, and milestone check-ins to catalyze early progress.

Opening

Interviewer

I'm researching how students actually go about forming teams for class project, the messy real version, not the ideal version. There's no right answer, and if something felt awkward or pretty at the time, that's exactly the kind of detail I want. Okay to record / take notes?

Interviewee

Yeah, totally fine! Go right ahead. I've definitely had my fair share of awkward group formation moments, so I've got plenty to share.

Question 1

Interviewer

Walk me through the last time you had to form a team for a class project, start from the moment you found out you'd need a team. Where did this happened, was it announced in class, over Slack / Discord, or did people just start clumping together in the room?

Interviewee

So, as you know, we usually know which courses have group projects beforehand because all assignments are listed in the ECP before the semester starts. But the actual group formation happened during our Week 1 tutorial. The tutor introduced a quick icebreaker activity to get people talking across tables. After that, he announced that we had until the end of Week 1 or up to Week 2 as the deadline to lock in a group and fill in the Google Form. You can also go to Microsoft Team or Ed Dashboard to post "looking for team", through not many use that. Most people try to sort it out right there in the tutorial during or after the icebreaker.

Interviewer

Who did you approach first, or who approached you? What made that person the first move?

Interviewee

During the icebreaker activity, I was paired up with the person sitting next to me. We chatted a bit while doing the exercise, so once the tutor announced the team deadline, it felt very natural to just ask, “Hey, want to form a team?” He agreed right away. It was convenient, and the icebreaker helped break the initial awkwardness.

Interviewer

Was there a moment of “who’s still left” or scrambling near the end? What was that like?

Interviewee

Yeah, definitely. Since we needed four people, we managed to grab a third person in class, but we were still missing one. We posted on the dashboard discussion board after class, but nobody replied for a couple of days. Eventually, in Week 2, the tutor randomly placed a student into our group who hadn’t shown up to the Week 1 tutorial. That’s pretty common, tutors will just plug absent people into teams that aren’t full yet.

Interviewer

~~Did you already know these people beforehand, or was this a new connection formed just for the project?~~ Was there anyone you wanted on the team but didn’t end up with? What happened there?

Interviewee

I actually messaged a friend before class because I saw the ECP listed a group project, but by the time I reached out, his group was already locked in.

Interviewer

Looking back, is there anything about how that team came together that you’d change?

Interviewee

I think icebreaker sometimes helps a lot, but it’s annoying that when every

semester begins, you need to introduce yourself. And, it mostly just tests how outgoing you are in 5-10 minutes. I wish there was a more structured way on the dashboard beforehand to see people's strengths and working styles, rather than relying on who happens to sit next to you or having random people added in Week 2.

Question 2

Interviewer

Think of the best team experience you've had in a class project, what made it work? What was the mix of people like, did you know them well, a little, or not at all beforehand? Was it about the people, the way work got divided, communication, or something else entirely?

Interviewee

It was a design course last year. We had a full week after the first tutorial to finalize our team. I teamed up with one friend I knew from previous course, and we used the icebreaker time in class to recruit two others who seemed really engaged. What made it work was that everyone communicated clearly and took ownership of their parts right from Week 2.

Interviewer

Can you point to a specific moment in that project where you thought "okay, this team is actually good"?

Interviewee

Definitely. A week before our mid-term submission, we realized part of our user research section was missing crucial data. Someone raised it in our group chat, and within half a day, everyone agreed on a plan. One person updated the interview guides, another recruited two extra participants, and we got it resolved seamlessly. No drama, just prompt problem-solving.

Interviewer

How does that compare to a team that was just…fine? What was the actual difference?

Interviewee

A “fine” team waits until someone pushes them. They get things done, but you have to constantly check in on messages, and people only do the exact minimum needed. A great team takes initiative early and communicates without needing constant reminders.

Question 3

Interviewer

Has there been someone you actively steered away from teaming up with, either because you’d worked with them before, or just heard things? Was that based on direct experience with them, or reputation / what other people said?

Interviewee

Usually based on my own experience. In first year, I worked with someone who consistently were silent for days, missed internal team check-ins, and left their section super messy until the very last night, leaving the rest of us to fix it. I make sure not to team up with them again.

Interviewer

How early in the process could you usually tell it wasn’t going to work, before the project started, or only once you were deep into it? Were there red flags that turned out to be wrong?

Interviewee

You usually notice red flags in the first week or two. If someone skips the initial group chat setup, constantly pushes back internal milestones, or seems completely detached during tutorial discussions, it usually a strong sign they’ll lag behind later.

Interviewer

Is there a difference between “someone I’d avoid for a group project” versus “someone I just don’t get along with” generally?

Interviewee

Huge difference! Someone can be super quiet or not my usual friend type, but if they complete their work reliably and communicate on time, they’re a great teammate. On the other hand, someone can be really friendly and fun, but if they procrastinate and leave work unfinished, it creates a lot of stress.

Question 4

Interviewer

Tell me about a time you didn't get to choose, you were assigned or ended up in a random group. Walk me through what that was actually like, start to finish. What was your first reaction when you found out you didn't get to pick?

Interviewee

In one course, the course coordinator just randomly assigned everyone into groups before Week 2. My initial reaction was a bit anxious, because you have no control over work ethics or compatibility when it's fully random.

Interviewer

How did the group actually function compared to a group you'd have chosen yourself, better, worse, or just different? Was there a specific low point, or a specific moment things turned around?

Interviewee

At first, it was pretty slow. People were polite, but nobody wanted to take charge. A few weeks in, as a draft deadline was approaching, progress was lagging. I stepped up and suggested a clear breakdown of tasks with soft deadlines. Once everyone had specific roles assigned, they actually followed through well. It just required more effort upfront to establish structure.

Interviewer

Did that experience change how hard you tried to self-select the next time you had a group project? If you had the option to swap out at any point, would you have?

Interviewee

Definitely. Knowing that ECP list group assessments ahead of time, I started reaching out to potential partners early in Week 1 rather than leaving it to chance. In that random group, I didn't feel the need to swap once we got organized, but early on I was definitely concerned.

Question 5

Interviewer

~~When you do get to pick your own team, what's your actual process, not the ideal process, the real one? Do you have a go-to person or small group you tend to gravitate toward? Has your approach changed since first year?~~

What information do you wish you had about someone before deciding to team up with them

Interviewee

Two main things: target grade, whether someone wants a 6-7 or just passing, and working style, whether they like working ahead of time or doing things closer to the internal deadlines. Matching those saves a lot of friction.

Question 6

Interviewer

If you were the tutor, and had to split the whole class into groups yourself, no self-selection allowed, how would you actually do it? What information would you want about each student before grouping them? What would you specifically try to avoid creating?

Interviewee

I'd run a brief survey in Week 1 asking about skills, target grades, availability, and maybe a private preference field. I'd form teams with balanced skill sets and matching grade ambitions. I'd avoid putting high achievers with unengaged students just to balance things out, as that usually leads to one person carrying the load.

Interviewer

Do you think a fair method and a good-outcome method are the same thing, or do they trade off against each other? If there was a tool that could help with this, what's the one thing it would need to know about a person to group them well?

Interviewee

They trade off. Pure random assignment is fair on paper, but can produce uneven group dynamics. Good outcomes require considering work styles and expectations. If a tool assisted with this, the most important metric would be working style and reliability alignment, grouping people with compatible pacing and expectations.

Closing

Interviewer

Is there anything about forming teams for class project that’s annoyed you, surprised you, or that I just haven’t thought to ask about?

Interviewee

Social awkwardness is definitely a big factor. Even with 1 to 2 weeks to form groups or dashboard posts, it's hard to decline someone politely if you know your working styles don't match. Icebreaker helps make contact, but having structured ways to match based on working styles would make the whole process smoother.

Interviewer

That’s a fantastic insight. Thank you so much for taking the time to share all of this today!